



TEAMULATE · AI MARKETING DEPARTMENT

# 11 Human Hires vs. 11 AI Specialists

The cost, capacity, consistency and control trade-offs behind a modern marketing department.

Public-facing comparison · United States + Canada national benchmarks · August 2026

**US \$960K**

U.S. salary-only benchmark (US \$960,490)

**C\$866K**

Canada salary-only benchmark (C\$866,486)

**90%**

up to lower people-cost, modeled — not a guarantee

A practical buyer guide for founders and lean teams deciding whether to build a traditional department, deploy an AI department, or combine both.

## THE THESIS

Most businesses do not actually need eleven additional payrolls. They need the coordinated capabilities those eleven specialists provide. Teamulate is designed to deliver broad marketing coverage through a coordinated AI agent team that can work from the same priorities, plans and operating context — while keeping humans in control of the decisions that genuinely require human judgment.

## 1. Executive summary and comparison rule

A fully staffed marketing department is powerful. Salary is the visible cost. The less visible cost includes employer payroll contributions, benefits, recruiting, onboarding, tools, management time, knowledge transfer, coordination, vacation coverage, sick leave, turnover, and the need to keep eleven people synchronized.

National wage benchmarks from August 2026 put an eleven-role structure at approximately US \$960,490 in U.S. base annual wages and C\$866,486 in annualized Canadian base wages. After employer-cost relationships (BLS ECEC March 2026; Canadian employer CPP/EI plus an illustrative 15% benefits-plan premium), modeled total employer compensation is about US \$1,401,956 (~US \$116,830/month) and C\$1,060,174 (~C\$88,348/month). That is before recruiting, equipment, software, office costs, provincial payroll taxes, workers compensation, severance or turnover.

### IMPORTANT COMPARISON RULE

This is a comparison of functional coverage, not a claim that one AI agent is a human employee equivalent. Humans and AI are different operating resources. Teamulate is intended to cover specialized marketing functions with coordinated agents, while human leadership remains essential for business judgment, brand taste, sensitive approvals and accountability.

## 2. What an 11-person marketing department actually costs

United States figures are BLS median annual wages. Canada figures are Government of Canada Job Bank wages annualized at 2,080 hours.

| Illustrative role                            | United States / median annual (USD) | Canada / annualized median (CAD) |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Marketing Director / Strategy Lead           | US \$166,790                        | C\$115,003                       |
| Marketing Strategist                         | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| Market & Competitive Research Analyst        | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| SEO / GEO Specialist                         | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| Content Writer / Copywriter                  | US \$76,910                         | C\$76,565                        |
| Social Media & Community Specialist          | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| Email / Lifecycle Marketing Specialist       | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| Paid Media / Demand Generation Specialist    | US \$78,760                         | C\$74,006                        |
| Graphic Designer                             | US \$62,960                         | C\$65,000                        |
| Video Editor                                 | US \$75,420                         | C\$72,010                        |
| Marketing Operations & Automation Specialist | US \$105,850                        | C\$93,870                        |

U.S. load uses BLS ECEC March 2026 for management and professional private-industry workers: wages \$53.50/hour plus \$24.59/hour in benefits (~46% above wages). Canada adds 2026 employer CPP/EI outside Quebec (about C\$63,700 on this wage base) plus an illustrative 15% benefits-plan premium (about C\$130,000), or roughly 22% above Canadian wages. Job Bank reports that 95.5% of marketing managers receive at least one non-wage benefit. Those are research facts, not a savings headline.

### 3. Hidden operating cost

- Time off is coverage you still pay for.
- Knowledge lives in people and leaves with turnover.
- Recruiting is a bottleneck, not a weekend task.
- Coordination — meetings, briefs, handoffs — is a hidden headcount.

#### THE ALIGNMENT PARADOX

Disagreement can surface better ideas. AI alignment is an advantage only when the direction is good. If the brief is wrong, aligned agents will be wrong together.

### 4. What changes with an AI marketing department

Teamulate delivers capabilities through eleven named seats, not eleven chatbots: Strategos, Scout, Wordsmith, Seeker, GrowthTrack, Pixel, Flow, Socialite, Nexus, Metric and Guardian. The mapping to human functions is coverage, not a one-to-one employee swap.

### 5. Human team vs. Teamulate

| Dimension          | 11-person human department                                                   | Teamulate AI department                                                                |
|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fixed cost         | High. Eleven full-time salaries plus employer costs.                         | Subscription-based and materially lower than full headcount.                           |
| Availability       | Primarily business hours; true 24/7 coverage requires shifts or more people. | Agents can run scheduled and approved workflows around the clock.                      |
| Alignment          | Requires meetings, briefs, handoffs and repeated re-synchronization.         | Shared objectives and operating context can update multiple agents together.           |
| Scale              | Usually requires hiring, onboarding and management capacity.                 | Parallel workloads can expand faster, subject to tool, model and platform limits.      |
| Consistency        | Depends on each person, manager, process and handoff quality.                | Style guides, checklists and shared rules can be applied repeatedly.                   |
| Human judgment     | Excellent for nuance, taste, relationships and ambiguous decisions.          | Useful for analysis and execution, but needs human ownership for high-stakes judgment. |
| Failure mode       | Absence, turnover, silos, miscommunication, uneven process.                  | Hallucination, stale context, bad instructions, tool failure or over-automation.       |
| Creative diversity | Different people bring different taste and dissent.                          | Shared models can converge; alternative directions have to be asked for.               |
| Brand consistency  | Varies by person, manager and enforcement.                                   | A style guide can be applied on every pass.                                            |

| Dimension              | 11-person human department                        | Teamulate AI department                                                            |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Institutional memory   | Lives in people; leaves with turnover.            | Shared context can persist; it still goes stale if nobody updates it.              |
| Scaling volume         | Usually means hiring.                             | Parallel workloads can expand faster, inside platform limits.                      |
| Absence risk           | Vacation, sick leave and resignations open holes. | Agents do not take PTO; approving humans still do.                                 |
| Quality control        | Depends on managers and available review time.    | Independent QA can run on every draft; high-stakes work still needs a human owner. |
| Accountability         | Named employees and employment law.               | Humans remain accountable. Agents are not employees.                               |
| Customer relationships | Strong for nuance and trust.                      | Useful for preparation; humans stay closest to the relationship.                   |
| Optimization speed     | Limited by meetings and capacity.                 | Monitoring and iteration can run continuously inside approved limits.              |

## 6. Where humans are still better — and where AI is stronger

Humans remain better at strategy that depends on taste, brand judgment outside the guide, relationships, risk calls, and accountability. AI is stronger at research assembly, preparation, production and repetition, monitoring, reporting, documentation and cross-channel execution from one context.

### THE HYBRID PRINCIPLE

Keep humans closest to strategy, taste, relationships, risk and accountability. Keep AI closest to research, preparation, production, repetition, monitoring, reporting, documentation and cross-channel execution.

The practical difference is not “AI works while humans do nothing.” Humans spend less time moving information between specialists and more time deciding what to do next.

## 7. The risk of perfect alignment

A human team leaks. People disagree, forget, or ignore a brief they do not believe. That waste is real — and so is the accident that a dissent surfaces the better idea. An AI department will not give you that accident for free. Compensation has to be designed in: a human who can reject the strategy; an explicit request for alternative creative directions; Guardian on claims; Metric measuring independently; and a rule that stale context is a stop, not a push-through.

## 8. A realistic campaign scenario

| Stage                          | 11-person human department                                                                       | Teamulate AI department                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Brief and priorities        | Director and strategist write the brief, then re-explain it as the week moves.                   | Strategos drafts the brief from shared priorities. A human approves the direction before work fans out.            |
| 2. Research                    | An analyst gathers competitors and proof, then emails a deck that may already be out of date.    | Scout prepares the research pack from the approved scope. Humans still decide which claims are safe to use.        |
| 3. Messaging and content       | Writer, social and lifecycle each interpret the brief. Tone drifts unless someone re-syncs them. | Wordsmith and Socialite work from the same message map. Guardian checks claims before publish.                     |
| 4. Creative production         | Designer and editor wait on copy, then wait on feedback. One absence slips the sequence.         | Pixel produces design and motion variants from the approved brief. Brand-system changes still wait for a human.    |
| 5. Search, site and demand     | SEO, web and paid configure in parallel and often discover the page does not match the ad.       | Seeker, Flow and GrowthTrack prepare against the same brief. Launches and budget changes stay on an approval gate. |
| 6. Operations, tracking and QA | Ops wires the forms. Someone else notices the UTM is wrong after the first send.                 | Nexus prepares routing and tracking. Guardian and Metric check readiness before the work is treated as live.       |
| 7. Readout and next decision   | A manager pulls numbers from three tools and books another meeting.                              | Metric prepares the readout with limitations stated. A human decides whether to scale, hold or stop.               |

## 9. What “up to 90% lower” means

The live public people-cost claim is up to 90% lower — modeled, not a guarantee. Software and advertising spend sit outside the percentage on both sides. The baseline in this report is the eleven-role national wage set, then the modeled employer load. Your baseline may be smaller, larger, or different by city. The percentage moves with that baseline and with the Teamulate plan you actually buy.

Public prices, in CAD: Core C\$7,500 setup + C\$5,000/mo; Growth C\$12,500 + C\$7,500/mo; Scale C\$20,000 + C\$12,000/mo. Those are retainers for a coordinated department, not a promise that output will match eleven specialists hour for hour, and not a USD sticker.

### CREDIBLE POSITIONING

The honest claim is not “AI equals eleven employees.” It is coordinated access to eleven specialties without an eleven-person payroll.

## 10. Who should choose which model

- **Teamulate** when you need broad coverage and will stay in the loop on judgment, but do not want eleven additional payrolls.
- **Hybrid** when a human stays closest to strategy, taste and relationships, and the department carries research, production, repetition and monitoring. Hybrid is the default honest shape.
- **Human-team-first** when the work is the relationship, the product is highly original creative direction, or the risk profile requires a fully human chain of employment.

## 11. Buyer questions

**Is this a claim that one AI agent equals one employee?** No. Functional coverage, not employee-equivalence.

**What do the figures describe?** An illustrative eleven-role department using BLS and Job Bank national wages, then modeled employer load. Not a quote for your market.

**Do I still need a human marketing lead?** You still need humans closest to strategy, taste, relationships, risk and accountability.

## 12. Decision

**Build the capability before you build the payroll.** Hire the named human when the work has proven it needs one.

## 13. Sources and methodology

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, national median annual wages (August 2026 pull).
- BLS Employer Costs for Employee Compensation — March 2026, management and professional private industry: \$53.50/hour wages + \$24.59/hour benefits.
- Government of Canada Job Bank — median wages annualized at 2,080 hours; 95.5% of marketing managers reported to receive at least one non-wage benefit.
- Canada Revenue Agency — 2026 employer CPP and EI outside Quebec, applied as about C\$63,700 on this wage base.
- Canada Life / typical benefits-plan context — an illustrative 15% benefits-plan premium (~C\$130,000 on this wage base).

This generated PDF restates the public comparison. It is not a scan of the original designed 16-page report. Software and advertising spend are excluded from people-cost percentages. Modeled, not a guarantee.

